

MIDTERM

CHAPTER 2: I'M A FILIPINO BUT I DON'T KNOW MANANSALA!

REDISCOVERING PHILIPPINE ART

Introduction

Philippine art in general is poignant, romantic, and even nostalgic. Before we were influenced by Westerns, we were already developing our own sets of culture and values. During the colonial period, gradually we became infused by foreign influence. In a way, it is quite saddening how the good heritage of old Filipino manners, ethics, and even cultural markers like our own "baybayin" were superimposed by newer trends. Most of us, especially in our generation, cultivated the idea that old fashioned is old school. Even the beautiful way of courtship is gone in the mist of the past: no more haranas and fewer dalagang Filipinas. Philippine art, on the other hand, has been conscious of these changes and has become a way to reminisce and remember our old virtues and rich roots. That is why it is very important to study Philippine art. It is part of our identity and that simply because we have a beautiful culture worth celebrating.

LESSON 1: HOW PHILIPPINE IS PHILIPPINE ART?: A SURVEY ON THE MARKERS OF OUR ARTISTIC CULTURE

Filipino artists are important forces in the formation of our national identity. Images and the culture of making artwork have power in itself. These are some notable artists who have captured our Filipino sensibilities in their own way:

1. Fernando Amorsolo interpreted the "Philippine Light"

We can compare his style with the impressionist painters who also aimed to express the simple beauties of nature and life. Such artists are Auguste Renoir, Edouard Manet and 19- century portrait artist Auguste Dominique Ingres. Because of Amorsolo's expertise on his medium, which is oil, and his sensitivity to light, Amorsolo was able to paint luminous skin as light strikes it and creates a certain glow. Others even say that you can almost feel the blood rushing underneath the flesh

He was coined as the master of Philippine Light. This is kind of light that when it strikes tanned flesh or the leaves of trees for example, one can immediately see a range of analogous or related colors such as yellow green, yellow and white that appear at the same time and makes one feel the warmth if the scene created. Because of his, excellent style, his paintings never fail to bring back the warmth and idyllic scenes of Philippine provinces and traditions.

2. Vicente Manansala developed his rendition of transparent cubism technique

Cubism was pioneered jointly by Pablo Picasso and George Braque and was described to be most radical innovation of art "isms" since it contrasted greatly with the classical perception of beauty. It uses overlapping and multi-perspective geometric shapes and forms of the chosen subject to produce depth.

The cubist aspect of Manansala has broader facets and planes than original cubism so they bring out larger rhythms and is closer to Synthetic Cubism rather than its earlier phase, which is Analytical Cubism. He further developed it into transparent cubism, which shows panels of shapes interfacing each other.

C . Unlike Amorsolo, Manansala echoes the proletarian painters of the United States. His works were non-idyllic: emotions and backgrounds showing evidence of real events happening at his time like poverty and economic depression and skin tones are not luminous kayumannagi.

3. Hernando R. Ocampo's style was considered by some critics as the most Filipino

. Most of HR Ocampo's works are purely abstraction, therefore it is hard to pinpoint why he was described as the most Filipino painter ever. However, it is not the content but rather the style of his works where one can see his unique painterly approach.

. What is unique in his works are the abstract compositions of biological forms that are portrayed in bold strokes of colors that seem to oscillate before your eyes. His subject matters are usually nature's flora and fauna, hence reflective of the natural beauty of his country.

4. Napoleon Abueva's modernist but Filipino-themed sculptures

. Characterized by the planar and geometric look of his sculptures, Abueva veered away from the conservatism of his mentor , Guillermo Tolentino (known for sculpting the University of the Philippines " Oblation"

. He still kept Filipino themes in his sculptures such as rice planters, mother and child, carabaos, and the like. However, his bold and edgy interpretation of such themes intensified the kind of spirit present in dynamic and often monumental sculptures.

Lesson 2: What's Happening? A Bite Of Visual Arts History of the Country

1. Pre -colonial Indigenous Art

. Characterized by use of materials found in the immediate environment combining functionality with aesthetics and art forms are usually connected to traditional belief systems and local values.

. Clay pottery is one of the earliest forms of ancient art which is evidence of artistic skill. The Manunggul jar of Palawan is a prominent example. Other forms are the Calatagan jar which displays inscriptions on its body and the Maitum burial jar. The maitum is anthropomorphic, meaning it mimics a human figure with facial expressions of sadness and joy on its face.

Other variations are the palayok which is used for cooking, the banga, tapayan (liquid container) and the burnay pottery of Ilocos.

Wood Carving is another prominent art form. Our animistic, mostly from the Cordilleras, carved the bul-ul and many variations of it. The bul-ul bi-functional, both a granary God and an ancestral spirit.

Weaving was also predominant we are very rich in materials like the buri, rattan, pandan and bamboo splits. Used in making hats and baskets like the pasiking backpack.

2. Hispanic Influence (1800's)

The main force of art is the church, hence works were mostly concerned with religious subject matters.

Notable artworks are (Philippine flora and fauna) and the Letras Y Figuras.

Filipinos were trained by friars and but they adhered to a more rich palette like red, blue, and yellow.

3. American Influence (1990's)

Closing of the Escuela de Pintura, Grabado Y Escultura which paved for the opening of small workshops led by artists to train pupils.

Photo ethnography was done by American soldiers to "prove" the uncivilized and primitive people of the Philippines.

Forces of art were commissions, sales, gifts, and opening of new American-based businesses.

Filipinos started getting involved in international art expositions like Felix Resurreccion Hidalgo.

4. Second Republic: 1942-1945

A. Japan occupies the country and laid the groundwork for cultural regeneration, dissipating American influence

B .Some artists involved in the movement were conservatives Fernando Amorsolo his brother Pablo , Guillermo Tolentino, Dominador and Castaneda and modernists Victorio Edades , Galo Ocampo and Hernando Ocampo.

C. Art became a vehicle of influence for the Japanese to control the Filipino spirit by restricting their artistic expression.

5. Third Republic: 1946-1972

Rise of modernism spearhead mostly by H.R. Ocampo, Victorio Edades, and Napoleon Abueva.

Art Association of the Philippines was formed along with the Philippine Art Gallery (PAG).

Main art movements were realism and neo realism with media- related conventions like komiks and editorial cartoons.

6. Fourth Republic 1972-1986

Marcos era; Marcos monument was created but was later destroyed.

First Lady Imelda Marcos efforts: Cultural Center of the Philippines (CCP), National Arts Center, and Philippine High School for the Arts among others. The CCP was envisioned as a shrine for high art and the avante garde.

C. Prominent artists were Chabet, Fernando Zobel, Raymundo Albano along with modern artists Manansala who painted "Madonna of the Slums" Benedicto Cabrera (Bencab) produced protest and revolutionary art through his paintings and prints. D. Antipas Delovato painted with watercolor a very striking work entitled "Itak sa puso ni Mang Juan."

7. Fifth Republic Onwards 1986- Present

Contemporary Philippine art

Rise of commercial galleries, improvement of institutions, and formation of more art groups and collectives.

Lesson 3: What is the Shape of Philippine Art?: Forms of our Art

In the field of Visual Arts, it is not much different. We can look back to one of the greatest Filipino artist of all time who were in the ranks with world-renowned painters and sculptors. Among them are Juan Luna and Felix Resurrection Hidalgo, both of whom represented the Philippines in the international exposition, Exposicion Nacional de Bellas Artes (national Demonstration of Beautiful Arts) in Madrid in the 1900s. These artists were first sponsored to study abroad and later on mastered their new knowledge to a different level of competency.

Forms of local art-The Philippines is very rich in terms of materials and resources. These materials are sometimes readily available and can be used in its raw forms, but others need to be processed. When these materials are put into use. Many techniques are given birth. The following are some of the major forms of Philippine art. Some have descriptions for us to further identify them.

Philippine Materials:

Lesson 4: How Do I Behave Myself in a Gallery?

Sometimes museums and galleries seem intimidating. Their erudite-looking façade can be too imposing that entering it seem to demand a lot from us. The culture of gallery and museum visits are not very common among us. We would rather go to malls where our

hunger for aesthetics could be relieved. However, we miss the opportunity of having an experience that will feed both our souls and our hunger for our deepest longings.

Museum and Gallery Etiquettes

How you dress- it does not always have to be too flashy or formal. Some special events in galleries and museums like opening receptions may be more special than regular, hence people would usually dress in formal attire. However, on a normal day museum or gallery visitors can just dress. Wear clothes which would show respect to such settings.

Where should you eat- some museums have cafes -the only areas where you are allowed to eat. In galleries, eating is only appropriate during openings and cocktails are usually served. However, these are not supposed to be full meals, they are just light snacks, so eat lightly and in the spaces designated for eating.

When taking photos - avoid using flash photography because the light could affect the vibrancy of a painting's color. Some paints are light-sensitive and they also naturally fade over time. Do not speed up the fading process by using the flash when clicking your camera.

Selfies and funny poses- In museums, a lot of paintings and artifacts are deeply venerated for their depictions of some of the most important pains and victories of a country or region. Hence, our behavior should also be properly coordinated.

Talking and jesting - it is definitely okay to talk and discuss some artworks, but if your voice is louder than normal, then it could distract and disturb other gallery visitors.

Touching - some contemporary art these days are meant to be touched, but most works are NOT. Our fingers have sweat glands which can affect the chemical properties of painting or sculpture's surface. Human sweat can be acidic and this can have deteriorating effects on a work of art.

Knowing the National Museum of the Philippines

We are blessed to have an established institution that houses some of the most important national and even world-renowned cultural heritage. These treasures are more than what money can buy because they are records of both history and human excellence. We will not always have a Luna living in our days, but his art is very much alive on the walls of our National Museum along with those of other Filipino artists.

The National Museum is a public space and is meant to be visited by us, the Filipino people. It was mandated in the year 1998 to acquire, document, preserve, exhibit, and foster scholarly studies and public appreciation of works of art, specimens, and cultural and historical artifacts representative of our unique cultural heritage and natural history. Here are some important aspects of the museum that you must know.

> It has nineteen (19) regional branches throughout the archipelago comprising the national network. Check if your local museum is part of this.

> The museum areas are in a complex. The National Art Gallery was formerly the Legislative building occupied by the Senate and House of Representative (lower ground then functioned as National Library); the National Museum of Anthropology) old finance building) and the newly - renovated National Museum of Natural History (formerly the department of tourism building).

National Museum of Fine Arts

Lesson 5: What NOW? The Contemporary Times

What is the pulse of art today?

The “now” is what critics call contemporary, or postmodern, which is the product of artistic sensibilities and attitudes following the modernist period. If we look at world events against its background, we can take into consideration one very important achievement: technology. Such was the context of the postmodern era. Critics were at first uncertain of how they should describe the movements following the modern period, but later on, contemporary art formed its shape and convinced us that it is an era of its own.

Technology and the rise of the World Wide Web have direct repercussions on the field of visual arts. New media was explored by artists. Subject matters were more diverse and also echoed the effects of technology. Approaches to art have become multi-faceted, multi-dimensional, and multi-modal. Since information and communication are now at our fingertips, the effects of globalization are also evident in our jobs, to the things we consume, to the international influences on our culture, and also to what we create in the art scene. In short, one key word to describe the arts that is happening in the “now”, is pluralism.

Precursors of postmodern art in the Philippines can be dated back to the EDSA 1 revolution. During the Aquino government, many reforms in the once Marcos controlled institutions like the CCP, National Museum, and Metropolitan Museum of Manila were implemented. There was a move toward the democratization, decentralization, and artistic excellence. Because of this, some marginalized artists and art groups during the Marcos regime were given opportunities to display their works to the public.

Let us now study the implications of contemporary issues for some artists whose works echo the issues you have discussed and debated previously.

Ben Cab- National Artist for Visual Arts - Benedicto Cabrera has works which span a lot of important periods in our history especially the postwar period. One of his work series entitled “Sabel” depicts the disorientation that Filipinos experienced during the postwar period.

David Medalla - The avatar in Europe in performance art as described by art critic Leo Benesa. Performance art is one of the new artistic expressions of the contemporary period where the artist himself is the artwork.

Pacita Abad - One of the women artists in the country that has produced a strong voice and identity when it comes to women's art. Born in Batanes, her works are characterized by bold and bright colors. She has traveled to more than 50 countries with works exhibited to more than 200 galleries.

Elmer Borlongan - Painter of Filipino nuances which he depicted with much dignity in his masterful works. His paintings are mostly figurative with subject matters that tackle

Mostly the daily and mundane activities and interactions of Filipinos. He is one of the most exceptional in the aspect of painting in our country.

Mark Salvatus - He has created much discourse and narratives in his works on the notions of urbanization, internet, and technological age, with political, social and economic grounding. His works are considered inter media, combining mark - making sounds, videos, and found objects in his works.

Leer-oy New- One of the youngest recipients of Thirteen Artists Awards, Leeroy is an artist of his own, known mostly for his installation art that are often other-worldly with an alien feel. He pioneered the “Aliens of Manila” which are curated photographs of people wearing his creations of bodysuits and headgear.

Archie Oculos- He has always been active in the public sphere, painting murals depicting social realities of both the present and the memories of the past governments. He was recently awarded one of the Thirteen Artists of CCP.

Mars Bugaoan - A young and emerging artist whose works echo the displacement that we often experience because of the demands of work and globalization. His works have evolved from printmaking to being site-responsive, incorporating the landscape of the site into the installation of the art piece.

Visual References from the Original Module





NATIONAL MUSEUM
PAMBANSANG MUSEO





Analogous



